Commerce and Industry in 2015, fully a third of Indian companies, and 25 percent of multinational corporations in India, were not compliant with the Sexual Harassment Act.[5] And while not nearly as widespread as the #MeToo movement that swept the United States, India's own version of public sexual shaming took off in 2018, with well-known public figures trading charges of sexual assault, harassment, and improprieties.

While crimes of violence and of a sexual nature are increasingly in the public eye, other types of social pressure and discrimination against Indian women remain pervasive. As for Sita, my coffeehouse companion, she tells me she would like to move from Chennai, but perhaps only to Bangalore, several hundred miles to the west, which is the space industry and IT capital of India and a magnet for young, educated Indians. She hopes that there her talent will be respected and that she might be freer to pursue her interests.

Sita's career path has been as indirect as her migration through India. At university, she majored in biology, finishing her degree through correspondence courses after her family's move south. But she never had an interest in working in the sciences and instead has a good service-sector job connected with Chennai's booming tourist and business population. She was hoping to become a duty manager at the hotel where she works, but even if she is promoted, she has decided to leave within a year to try and move into a sales position. But then, she admits, that probably won't happen either, since her parents are adamant about that marriage.

I ask Sita about her engagement. Her somberness comes not just from having her life partner picked out for her, but because she is in love with someone else. She has a boyfriend who is also a professional, but "it won't work out," she says. Because of her arranged engagement? No, because she doesn't know if he loves her. He works in Bangalore, one reason she wants to move there, but he is not ready to commit. Not that it would matter, she adds, since her parents don't like him. Our whole conversation is like this, with her starting a topic by talking